Fragments

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Teen And Up Audiences

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Kittrina (He-Man), Auravelle, Ariel, Lenio - Character

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Part 26 of Of Wing and Claw, Part 9 of Of Wing and Claw side stories

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by Paganaidd

Summary

Its been days since Akrash and Catra set out to save tiny Princess Isha. What's been happening in Halfmoon?

Read after Defiance chapter 135

Halfmoon Infirmary Royal Wing

Halfmoon Castle

Almost Exactly Four Years After Catra's abduction

Catra's birthday

Ariel surfaced slowly. Her side hurt and the blanket was too heavy. The pain in her gut had changed to a dull throb that pulsed with her heartbeat.

What day was it? She lost count.

“Auravelle?”

Next to her bed, Auravelle studied the monitor Ariel couldn’t see. Her ears swiveled on her head, tense and twitchy, her blue eyes slitted with concern.

“Yes?”

“Is it time for more pain meds?”

Auravelle’s eyes narrowed and she moved closer to touch two fingers to the edge of the dressing over Ariel’s wound, the same light, professional touch as before, and paused.

“Does this hurt?”

Ariel suppressed a yelp. “Y-yeah.” The numbing charm didn’t even touch it.

“Little burn.” Auravelle always warned her, which Ariel appreciated. The world went fuzzy around the edges.

Auravelle’s eyes unfocused for a moment, and Ariel felt a faint pressure under her ribs where the magic probed. Then the

hetaira's mouth went thin and she laid the back of her hand against Ariel's forehead.

"I'll be right back." She straightened, and walked quietly out into the corridor.

Ariel let her eyes slide shut, hoping that Auravelle hadn't gone to bother Lenio.. He had enough going on with Lyra and Auravelle was taking care of Kittrina as well as her. No one needed the stress of her slow healing wound on top of it. It would be fine. They had plenty of restorative. They could wait until Akrash came back.

"Ariel…" Lenio began in a tone that told her he was worried about her.

Ariel's eyes popped open. She was thoroughly tired of hearing that tone. Akrash used it too. He always had. She'd always thought of it as his "serious healer" voice.

"Auravelle says she's worried that there's something still in that wound we missed." Lenio said seriously. "I'm afraid we need to do a deep scan and possibly another surgery."

"No." The word came out before Ariel could stop it. "I can't."

Lenio's face scrunched in confusion. "Ariel?"

A low groan forced its way past her lips. "Please. I can't."

She needed to be awake. Kesi could come back any second. Akrash would bring her back. That made absolutely no sense. She had no evidence that Kesi was anywhere near Akrash, but she was convinced of it.

“Ariel?” Auravelle asked.

“What?” she asked irritably.

“Ariel, you have a fever.”

A fever? That would explain why everyone was annoying the shit out of her. “I’m sorry.” The whine in her own voice made her cringe.

“Its normal to be fretful when you’re feverish.”

The kind tone and gentle words felt like a judgement. The soft hand on her shoulder felt like a hundred pound weight, anchoring her to the infirmary while Kesi and Akrash needed her. She didn’t know why, but she was convinced they were together and in danger.

Auravelle bent over, meeting Ariel’s eyes and holding out a potion. “This is for your fever. We’ll hold off doing anything until it’s under control, okay?”

“Why?”

“Because doing surgery on someone with a fever is risky,” Lenio grunted.

“Surgery? Will you have to put me under?”

“Yes. I’m afraid so.” Lenio handed the tablet he was looking at to Auravelle. “Why?”

“Dr. Lenio!” A voice yelled urgently from the hallway.

“I’m sorry, that’s for the Queen.” He waved at the sound behind him. “I’ll be back to check in a few hours when that potion has had time to work. Okay?” He squeezed Ariel’s hand and left.

“Ariel? What’s wrong?” Auravelle kept her voice soft and calm.

“No. He can’t knock me out.” The words were flat. An immutable fact. “I-I won’t let him. Tell him no.” The night she’d returned from Snows, when Akrash carried her to the infirmary she’d already passed out and when she half woke, terrified, feeling like she was clawing at the lid of her coffin, Akrash was there. When she had been stabbed at the battle in Snows, Kesi was with her. This time she’d be *alone.*

Some sane brain cell tried to rally her common sense. She knew she was safe here. As safe, if not safer than she would be in Mystacor.

She’d been betrayed by those thoughts before. That was where it had happened.

“Ariel!” Auravelle’s eyes were wide and she rubbed Ariel’s trembling shoulders. “What’s wrong?” she asked again.

“I can’t… “ she couldn’t bear the thought of the anaesthetic. The pain killers made her drowsy, yes, but they didn’t make her helpless. They didn’t make her magic impossible to call. They didn’t make her feel like she was trapped.

For weeks after Khedir, she’d wake up unable to move, trapped in sleep paralysis, unable to call her magic. Helpless. She never knew if it was trauma or something the Glitter had done (she flatly refused to talk to one of the healers about it). One night Akrash heard her whimpering from the other side of the wall. After the first time, she thought he put a monitoring spell on her.

She’d wake up with him shaking her shoulder and an offer to make her tea. On those nights he’d sleep on her couch.

“I can’t…” She didn’t know how to explain. When she woke up from the surgeons in Snows putting her back together, she tried to strangle some poor nurse until Kesi had intervened, wrapping Ariel in her arms, letting her know she was safe.

That last time, Akrash had been here. When she woke he’d been holding her hand. Telling her as many times as she needed it,

where she was. When she was.

But more, he had been with her throughout the surgery. Linking their magic. Holding off the nightmares. His solid presence palpable to her sleeping mind, she'd been able to let his and Lenio's spells through her defenses.

"Ariel. When they brought you to the infirmary and we gave you the restorative, you woke up terrified. You took a swing at us." Auravelle whispered. "Do you always do that? What are you scared of?"

Ariel didn't remember that, but it sounded right. Had she hurt anyone? "Do you know what Glitter is?"

"No, I'm sorry."

"It…" How could Ariel explain? "It's an Etherian drug. Anaesthetic. They use it for recreation sometimes. And for…" She couldn't say it. She didn't even want to think about it."They use it to o-overpower sorcerers."

Auravelle stared at her for a long time. "This happened to you?"

Ariel never talked about this. She'd given Kesi the barest bones. Akrash had been there.

"Someone… dosed me with Glitter once. He… " She trailed off into a sob.

"Shh. Okay. I understand," she whispered as Ariel gave herself over to helpless tears.

Auravelle climbed into bed next to her as she'd done with Kitt and *oh* it helped so much. Her fur was fluffy and warm and the hug felt like it fulfilled some need as real as food and water. Was this the 'touch-starved" thing Lenio talked about?

When Ariel's cries quieted, Auravelle continued to stroke her shoulder. And then, "How comfortable are you with mind

sharing?”

Ariel blinked. That was how she’d gotten through the surgery to put her guts back in, but that was Akrash. “Is that… Can you do that?”

Auravelle nodded. “I can stay with you. Guard your sleep.”

Mind sharing was intimate and there was always the danger that the less powerful sorcerer could be overwhelmed. Akrash, and her mother were the only sorcerers (and maybe Lenio?) that Ariel was confident it *wouldn’t* happen to.

“I'm not as powerful as you or Akrash, but I have a lot of experience with the technique,” Auravelle explained. “I am very experienced with traumatic memories.”

Ariel blinked. She’d seen Auravelle’s skill. No wonder Aster had spiked her career.

“Why do you keep pretending to be less than you are?” she blurted.

Auravelle’s ears tilted back. “My family often asks the same thing.”

“No. I'm sorry. I meant… what you do… I meant…”

Auravelle’s face softened. “In a lot of ways, I’m like the mind-healers Akrash says Mystacor trains. We don’t have a formal class of healers like that. It’s generally seen as more the province of the faiths.” Her mouth quirked up. “And I’m not really cut out to be a priestess, but I’ve built my practice as a *hetaira* around it. I've spent years helping people illuminate dark corners of their minds.”

Dark corners, yes. Ariel’s mind had a lot of those, even before Khedir. “But I could…” She wasn’t afraid of what Auravelle could see, but she knew what could happen with a reversal.

“I’ve had mindshares reversed on me before. I know what to do.” Her lips were touched with a soft smile. “And with the drugs Lenio

uses, it’s not like you’ll remember any of my deep secrets.”

“Oh.” That *could* work, if Auravelle was all right with it.

Auravelle pursed her lips, her gaze going unfocused as she looked *through* Ariel.

“I'll be honest, Ariel.” Her eyes returned to Ariel’s face now. “I think if you weren’t so powerful, you'd be dead. I suspect whatever surgeon worked on you in Snows left something on purpose. Maybe a shard of metal or something that could slowly release the venom.”

That made a scary amount of sense.

“But wouldn’t Akrash and Lenio have found it?”

“Not if it's meant to hide.” She looked away. “It was Aster’s favorite trick. Plant a spell with a trigger that goes off weeks or months later. I’m betting it’s a common Horde tactic. This is probably meant to work anytime you try to use a particular threshold of magic.”

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“She’s afraid of the anaesthetic." Auravelle told Lenio when he returned, a couple hours later. The conference room was quiet and he'd had their lunch set up in there, since Kitt was still sharing her room with Ariel. “She got dosed once with something that suppressed her magic and I guess something bad happened.”

Lenio’s ears went back. “Damn. That explains it.”

“What?”

“When we were putting her guts back in, Akrash handled all the anaesthetic. And then he did a mindsharing spell. He said he was afraid she’d hurt someone if he didn’t.”

Auravelle nodded. “She’s willing to do the surgery if I do a mindsharing with her. We talked about it.”

“That’s risky. I’ve never seen anyone as powerful as she is other than Akrash or Lyra.”

“I think if you have Triana handle the cold sleep and have Geoff assist the surgery, I can put all my power into the mindsharing. She already knows Geoff and Triana. That will help.”

“That sounds like a plan. I’ll tell them. We can do it this evening.”

“All right.” Auravelle stood and stretched, hands over her head, bending backward, letting out a long groan. Her back hurt. She wasn’t used to being on her feet like this all day, nor was she a morning person. It was lunchtime in the infirmary, but at Nine Winds, she’d just be getting out of bed.

“You okay?” Lenio asked.

“Yes. I think I should start taking the night shift, though. Day shift kills me.” A wry smile crossed her lips as she dropped her arms and looked down at her mentor. “I’ll be happy when Akrash gets back.”

“Is he still…?” A twist of the old man’s mouth showed his worry.

“He’s alive.” Auravelle assured him softly. “So are Isha, Catra, Imella and Duncan.”

“We have a few hours before we can do anything with Ariel. Do you want to go home and sleep for a few hours in your own bed?”

The offer was tempting but Auravelle thought of Kitt. She could not leave her alone.

“No. Thank you. I’ll catch a nap here before the surgery.”

“See that you do. I know you’re working too much.”

"Takes one to know one."

"I'm old. I'm allowed."

Auravelle rolled her eyes and scoffed.

Back in their room, Ariel was asleep, the lights were dim, and Kitt was listening to a book. Her ears tilted back a little and she shut it off when Auravelle came in, the scent of embarrassment heavy.

Sadness stabbed Auravelle's heart. Kitt kept doing this; being guilty over every pleasure. "What were you listening to?" she asked, keeping curiosity bright in her voice.

"Oh, it's nothing. Just… you know. A Founding Era romance." She bit her lip as though she expected Auravelle to laugh at her.

"Oooh! I love those!" She sat on the edge of the bed she'd been sharing with Kitt. Technically Kitt could have been released from the infirmary, but between the security restrictions and Kitt's own reluctance to go back to her rooms in the Queen's residence alone, it made sense to keep her here. They'd brought in a bigger bed and Clarence had brought some of Auravelle's bedding from home. With what she was going through, Kitt deserved some no-strings-attached cuddles.

"Why don't you turn it back on? Ariel's surgery is scheduled for this evening and Lenio ordered me to take a nap."

Kitt turned it back on.

"I love this one!" Auravelle trilled. "*The Lady of Two Hearths!*"

"You… you don't think it's silly?" Kittrina's voice was very small and her eyes flicked to Ariel. "I mean with everything going on…"

"With everything going on, it's even more important to allow ourselves pleasure." The comforter felt good as she tucked herself in, not even bothering to take off her scrubs. She snuggled down

into the warmth and turned on her side so she could look at Kitt. “Stories are important. Laughter is important. Love is important.”

“I feel so guilty though…”

“Depriving yourself won’t help Akrash or Isha. It won’t fix anything.”

“But…”

“I read a parable once, of a man who falls over a sheer cliff. He catches himself with one hand on a bush growing from the rockface. But he’s alone. And too far down to climb back up, but too high to survive the fall. On the bush is one perfect berry. And so he ate the berry. And it was the best berry he’d ever eaten.”

Kittrina blinked at her. “I don’t understand.”

Auravelle shrugged. “Scholars have debated the meaning for years, so I won’t interpret it for you. But *I* think it means that pleasure is not silly. You are fighting a hard battle. My mother always says that battles are won and lost on morale. So, think of it that way if it helps.” She paused and pointed at the tablet with her chin. “Have you ever spoken to the author? She’s lovely.”

Kitt’s ears pinned. “Oh no, I couldn’t.”

“Why not? She would be absolutely delighted to hear that you enjoy her work.” She leaned in a little. “She actually asked me for an introduction. She wants to write you and Akrash’s story.”

“Why?”

“Because you and Akrash have captured the imagination of the Midnight Bazaar. He has far more friends there than he knows and now so do you.”

“They don't think I'm weak or foolish for…”

“For loving someone? For trusting your husband? For petitioning for a divorce when it became clear he wasn't worthy of that love? For fighting the whole damned Council? Oh, no.” Auravelle reached out a hand and stroked Kitt’s cheek. “They talk about how brave you are for standing up to Lord Aster and the Council. How you fought the kidnappers and dueled Trishiam with two knives in you. How you defended the Queen. It's already a legend.”

Kitt teared up and buried her face in Auravelle’s neck. They’d been doing this all week, whenever Kitt got overwhelmed, by fear, or grief or guilt.

Auravelle had promised Akrash she'd take care of Kitt. And as long as she had strength in her, she would honor that.

***

Ariel was already on the table when Auravelle came in, red hair hidden under a cap, bare skin impossibly pale, the drape folded back from her side. Lenio stood at the head with the scanner. Geoff had his tray. Triana stood on the far side of the table with her arms crossed, worried but determined.

“Ready?” Lenio asked Ariel.

“No.” Ariel’s voice was small. “But let’s do it anyway.”

Auravelle pulled a stool up beside the head of the table and sat so her knees touched the rail, awash in magic as she cast the sterile barrier spell on herself. Then she cast a privacy spell in preparation for the mindsharing.

“Ariel,” she said. “Tell me what you’re afraid of right now.”

Ariel wrapped her hand around Auravelle’s. “That I’m helpless. That my magic won’t come when I need it.”

The cold hand in Auravelle's grasp trembled as she opened the thinnest magical channel between them. "Can you feel that?"

Ariel nodded, her green eyes locked on Auravelle's.

"I'm right here. Triana is going to start the meds and do the cold-sleep spell." Auravelle took a long centering breath, letting more magic flow through her foci, directing it with her intent, asking Ariel's defenses to allow her in. She braced for the backwash. Then she said the words to shape it into a protective mindshare.

"I will stand between you and harm in whatever dark places you must walk."

"What if it's not dark?" Ariel's mind-voice whispered as the spell took hold.

"There too."

In Ariel's mind they walked together, through an elegant crystal hallway, merry crowds around them.

Flash.

They were in a room. Something blew into Ariel's face.

Flash.

Someone held her down.

"You should have stayed a slave."

"No." Dream Ariel cringed and reached for a sigil.

Auravelle pushed the memory back. "I'm here. I'm here. Where can I take you? Who will help you?"

Dream Ariel started to cry and dream Auravelle held her. "I want my brother!"

"Let's go find him."

Ariel's mind began to calm under the influence of the drugs, the cold sleep and the mindshare. They walked together and the shifting shadows retreated from Auravelle's light.

Flash.

Ariel stumbled, but then the dream image of Akrash appeared. Tired and worn, wearing the same robes he wore to rescue Isha.

"Aury! What the fuck?!"

Auravelle jumped. A memory should not react to her presence.

She reached out with her magic, a tentative little probe that was met with the unmistakable signature of blue-white power.

It was Akrash. A phantom, yes, but a sending, not a memory.

"What are you doing here?"

"Akrash!" Ariel threw herself into his arms, sobbing as he caught her. "I can't wake up. Take me home. Please," she begged, too confused by the drugs to understand what was happening.

"Aury?" He hugged his sister, looking over her head to gape at Auravelle.

"Lenio's got her in surgery. I'm mindsharing because she was so scared."

"Surgery! What happened?"

They didn't have time for this. "I assume you're sending for a reason? Spit it out!"

Akrash blinked and shook his head. "Yes! We're at Catra's Cove! We have Isha! She's safe. We have Kesi!"

Ariel went still against him.

"We're all alive! But, we can't walk back. We need a train. We have Seahawk and his crew. And Glimmer of Bright Moon. Tell the Queen!"

Fuck. Catra's Cove? How could he send so far? And Seahawk? People from Bright Moon? That sounded insane. Ariel wouldn't remember this. Panic welled up hot and acid in Auravelle's throat. Would anyone believe her?

No. It was different now. She had friends in the castle. Lenio would believe her. So would Kitt.

She hoped.

If they didn't, she'd steal a fucking train. Aden would help her. And he'd talk Lerrys into it.

"I'll tell them!" she promised.

He took Ariel gently by the shoulders. She wouldn't let go of him.

"Ariel. You have to let me go. Aury'll take you home. I promise. I trust her with my life. Okay?" Gently he put Ariel's arms around Auravelle. Then he dropped his hand to her cheek. "Aury… I don't know how…"

"Shut up, and let the connection go, you idiot!" Auravelle snapped. "Do you want to burn yourself out?!"

His ears went back and his tail lashed. Instead of answering, he nodded and his form faded away.

Flash.

"Auravelle?"

That was Lenio's voice, calling from the real world. "We're bringing her up."

"Come on, Ariel. We're going home."

“Promise?”

“I promise.”

But before she could disengage cleanly, magic surged up around her. Ariel’s copper and golden threads of fire wrapped around her, pulling the mindshare inside out. She’d prepared herself for this. She knew better than to fight it. Instead, she let the memories flow around her, reminding herself they were merely flickers of light on the cavern wall.

Flash.

A hallway near the infirmary.

Grey-furred hands holding hers. Lips brushing quickly before anyone saw. Watching him walk away next to his sire and knowing he was going to pay for some imagined crime.

Flash.

An alley. She was throwing up.

Flash.

Another castle hallway.

“Oh look, it’s Lord Imoh’s daughter. The crazy one.”

Flash.

Madame Bastet’s office.

“I have enough soft pretties. You’re not special, girl! Come back when you’re sober.”

Flash.

The fertility clinic.

Oh, no. Not this.

It was too new. Too raw. She couldn't just let it flow. It stuck to her, and the pain wasn't one she was accustomed to. She didn't know how to bear it yet.

"Don't give up hope completely. Even if your magic won't respond to the fertility spells, you're young and you could still find an imprint. That often overcomes this kind of issue."

An imprint was no hope at all, just another dagger in her heart. The one person she could stand to see her like that was gone. His fur burned white by his own will. She was only the reminder of a rejected name and wounds long healed. She'd known since the day she saw that braided cord…

No. Nononono…

Auravelle yanked herself out of the magic and stumbled backwards, terrified and grief stricken .

Arms held her. Geoff was picking her up from the floor. Her stool had tipped back, and she felt his hands check for bumps on the back of her head.

"Aury?" Ariel's cracked whisper brought her fully into the real world. "Are you still here? I'm cold."

Auravelle pushed Geoff away, scrambled up and grabbed the rails of the table. "I've got you. I'm here." She wrapped both hands around one of Ariel's. "Your magic! Call it!"

Green eyes full of wonder and confusion, Ariel held up her hand and summoned a sigil. It flashed, and the terror faded from Ariel's eyes.

"Aury? Thank you." Her eyes slid shut as she let it go. Heated IV fluid flowed into her, warming her body, bringing her out of the cold sleep.

"You found it?"

Lenio held a specimen tray with a thumbnail-sized bit of flesh. "You were right. They disguised it as a bit of scar tissue."

She was right. Lenio had believed her, and he'd found it.

"Ariel's magic surged as soon as I took it out. Sorry." Lenio peered at her, ears back. "Are you okay?"

Auravelle's hand shot out to grab his wrist. "I'm fine! But Akrash! He sent to Ariel while we were mindsharing!"

The glance that passed between Triana and Geoff nearly made her panic. She wanted to beg Lenio to believe her but knew this would do no good for her credibility. "He and Catra. Kesi. They're at Catra's Cove. They've got Isha! And Seahawk. And an envoy from Bright Moon!"

"No one could send that far," Triana gasped.

"Akrash could," Lenio snapped at the apprentice. "Go on, Aury. What did they need?"

Lenio believed her. Auravelle nearly cried with relief.

"A train. They need a train. I-I think they have injuries? They need it as soon as we can get it there!"

Lenio nodded. He turned to Triana and Geoff. "Get Auravelle to bed. Monitor Ariel. I have to talk to the Queen."

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